

NARMADA MOVEMENT

■ By Ambreesh Mishra

Before Singur and Nandigram hit the national headlines, Narmada Valley was the original ground zero for agitations against big projects. One of the largest, longest and most successful environmental campaigns in the country, Narmada Bachao Andolan (NBA) began in 1987 with a wide developmental agenda, questioning the very rationale of large dam projects like the Sardar Sarovar Project (SSP). Under the leadership of Medha Patkar, it has had remarkable victories, the most notable being the withdrawal of World Bank funding of \$455 million (Rs 1,789 crore) from SSP. Surviving allegations ranging from dubious foreign funding and pushing the agenda of global energy players to simply being anti-Gujarat, it has earned for itself an eclectic group of adherents, from Arundhati Roy to Aamir Khan.

However, nearly 20 years after it

began, the andolan stands at a crossroads. A rapidly modernising India has largely ignored the model espoused by NBA and the Supreme Court—through which its most notable victories have come—has blunted the agitation by declining to stay the raising of the dam's height to 121.92 m.

Despite these setbacks, NBA has managed to re-invent itself with Patkar expanding her role in issues outside Narmada, and a second line of leadership, including Alok Agarwal and Chitruha Palit, mobilising communities affected by similar dam projects in Madhya Pradesh. Abdul Jabbar, who leads the movement for the rights of Bhopal gas tragedy victims, says, "If it

weren't for NBA, the state governments wouldn't have even met the requirements of the Narmada Water Disputes Tribunal award, let alone offer better packages for the affected families." Now, the andolan's active intervention means those displaced in Madhya Pradesh won't be shortchanged either. ■

SUSHIL VARMA, Narmada Authority, 1987

"Our topmost priority will not be construction of the dam, but rehabilitation of the displaced."

Putting People FIRST

AP PHOTO GURINDER OSAN

By giving voice to others displaced on the march to growth, the NBA continues to fight the good fight beyond the valley

ANGRY ACTIVIST:
Patkar protesting in
Delhi in June 2006

